

**“ But O heart! heart! heart! O
the bleeding drops of red,
Where on the deck my Captain
lies, / Fallen cold and dead.”**

WALT WHITMAN, FROM HIS POEM, *O CAPTAIN! MY CAPTAIN!*, 1865

Lincoln fights for survival

Meanwhile, desperate attempts were being made to save Lincoln's life. Too badly injured to be taken back to the White House, he was carried instead to a boarding house across the street from the theater. But there was little the doctors could do. Fatally wounded by a single bullet to the brain, the president died early the following morning without having regained consciousness. The hunt for the conspirators now began to intensify.

Capturing the culprits

Powell was the first to be apprehended, three days after the attack, when he returned to the boarding house where the plot had been hatched. Powell found federal agents sent to arrest the owner, a Confederate sympathizer named Mary Surratt, waiting for him there. Atzerodt was tracked down three days later on a Maryland farm some 25 miles (40km) from the capital. John Wilkes Booth managed to evade capture until April 26, when he was traced to a barn in Virginia and shot dead. Others who were party to the plot were also arrested, including David Herold. He had accompanied Booth on his flight, but chose to surrender to the pursuing troops rather than die trapped in the Virginia barn as it burned around him.

Toward a united country